

troops had the *Sturmgewehr*, the first assault rifle. Heavy, general-purpose, and light machine-guns were ubiquitous, as were submachine-guns, including the British *Sten* and the American Thompson ("Tommy") gun. Cavalry were mostly absent, although some armies still used horse-drawn supply trains – Germany assembled over 600,000 horses for its 1941 invasion of the Soviet Union.

TACTICS AND FORCES

Airborne troops emerged as a new elite branch of infantry, delivered to battle by parachute or glider. The Allies also conducted amphibious operations on a massive scale – particularly the US Marines in their "island-hopping" campaign against the Japanese in the Pacific. Resistance groups mounted guerrilla warfare in occupied territory, and irregular forces fought behind enemy lines.

However, land warfare in World War II was not only about mobility; infantry fought at close quarters for long periods at Stalingrad in the Soviet Union in 1942–43, and on Iwo Jima in the Pacific in 1945. Often, defensive positions were attacked by artillery barrage and infantry assault, supported with armoured vehicles – similar tactics, albeit with improved technology, to those used in World War I.

"The real secret is speed – speed of attack through speed of communication"

GENERAL ERHARD MILCH, DISCUSSING *BLITZKRIEG*, 1939



◀ US MARINES ON GUADALCANAL

World War II soldiers had to fight in a wide variety of environments. The Pacific island of Guadalcanal, the scene of intense combat between American and Japanese troops in 1942, was difficult jungle terrain.



KEY EVENTS

1919–45

- **1919** British Army officer J F C Fuller presents a plan for offensives based on penetration in depth by a strike force of massed tanks, supported by aircraft and motorized infantry battalions.
- **1928** American engineer J Walter Christie completes his design for a high-speed tank with a revolutionary suspension system.
- **1936** The US Army adopts the semi-automatic M1 Garand rifle, with an eight-round "en-bloc" clip (with cartridges and clip inserted in a fixed magazine) – a significant advance on existing bolt-action rifles.
- **May–June 1940** German *Blitzkrieg* tactics combine tanks, aircraft, and motorized infantry to break deep into enemy territory.
- **May 1941** An invading force of German paratroopers land on Crete.
- **July 1943** Massed German tanks are defeated at the Battle of Kursk by Soviet defences, including minefields and anti-tank guns.
- **1945** American troops make extensive use of flamethrowers on Iwo Jima and Okinawa.